

“Ben, how could you do that without even asking me?” Naomi said angrily.

“Wait a minute, Naomi. Let Ben explain. What’s done is done. Let’s just try to work this out,” Bryan suggested calmly. “Okay?”

“Naomi, I know it was stupid and I should have asked you, but I just got carried away when I stopped to look at the cars. And I honestly thought I could return it. I didn’t know they would charge a restocking fee.”

“Where does the car loan stand now, Ben?” Bryan asked.

“I signed a note for the \$650 so they would take the car back. Now they’re threatening to sue me if I don’t pay up. But I don’t know where the money will come from.”

“Okay, a \$650 note due and payable,” Bryan noted on his worksheet. “Anything else?”

“One thing,” Ben replied as he looked over at Naomi and saw her grimace. “I owe five hundred dollars on our Visa for a car navigation system I bought about a month ago.”

“I thought you saved the money to buy that from your overtime pay,” Naomi said.

“I did, but I decided that I should get the top of the line that had a built-in theft alarm—plus there was an installation fee. It all came to nearly five hundred, and I didn’t have the extra money, so I charged the whole thing.”

“What happened to the money you had from overtime?” Bryan asked.

“I kept it, planning to use that to pay the Visa bill,” Ben replied. “But somehow it all was spent before the bill came.”

“So now we owe another five hundred on the Visa?” Naomi looked away as the tears welled up in her eyes.

“Naomi, please calm down,” Bryan said in a gentle voice. “We knew the situation was bad, or you wouldn’t have come here. But I appreciate Ben’s honesty about the debts. I can’t be of any help to you if I don’t know the entire situation.